

that far behind.”

Ancy knows others are already taking notice of her. At the Asian Indoor Championships earlier this year, she says the Chinese audience loved what they saw.

“I even gifted some of my ornaments to one of the Chinese players, Shiqi Xiong [who won the gold medal and who is expected to be Ancy’s biggest challenge in Nagoya]. I gave her some of the rings and chains I was wearing. She likes that stuff a lot.”

In India, too, her personality has admirers.

“I know there are a lot of young athletes who look up to me. They’re willing to let their personalities come out more as well. And now that I have the national record, no one can say that the two can’t go together.”

And there is something even bigger on her mind.

When she closes her eyes, Ancy sees it clearly: 7 metres.

When she first arrived at the National Camp, she told coach Anoop Joseph that she wanted to jump that distance. “He was thinking, ‘Who is this little girl who thinks she’s going to jump 7m?’”

Even with the national record to her name, Ancy wants that 7m mark.

“6.88 is a number, but 7m is a brand. It’s a magical mark. It’s like being the first person in space. I want to be the first Indian to do it.

“I want to, of course, do well in the big tournaments, but I really want to jump 7 metres. When people think of who got to that mark, I want them to look at me and say, ‘It’s the one and only Ancy Sojan.’”



AFTER SETTING THE NATIONAL RECORD AT 6.88m, ANCY NOW AIMS TO BE THE FIRST INDIAN WOMAN TO BREACH THE 7m MARK IN LONG JUMP



RITU RAJ KONWAR